How do you judge it?

Assessment red flags

- Asking students to **summarise** literature (inc. methodologies)
- Data analysis/coding tasks without an **audit trail**
- Interview-based tasks without **evidence**
- Not having an **AI policy** in the assignment
- Non-actor-specific problems (tasks AI is good at)

Fixing the lack of guidance

"Communication science **lacks not only common guidance** for responsible genAI use, but also the **empirical foundation** needed to develop such guidance … Literature **rarely translates general principles into concrete practices**.

"The field **lacks systematic evidence about how genAI is used at different stages of research**, [and] **how communication scholars evaluate specific applications.**"

Ho, J. C. et al. (2026) 'Guidance over guidelines? Unpacking the uses and concerns of generative AI in communication science' 10.1080/1369118X.2026.2736810.

Please God, no.

“As with all scholarship and research, it is extremely important to reference sources of information and content including the use of AI. E.g.

(OpenAI’s ChatGPT AI [Large Language Model], personal communication, 31 March 2023)

Assessment and feedback - Aston University, September 2024
https://www.aston.ac.uk/sites/default/files/AI%20at%20Aston%20Sept%202024%201.ppt

Is every project now a group project?

AI is an invisible group member. Make it as easy as possible to declare if/what they contributed (and make it harder to claim ignorance/silence)

- **Declaration of AI usage form**: list the uses, Y/N required
- **AI transcripts as appendices**: “I used ChatGPT” isn’t enough
- **Allocate roles to AI**: e.g. specify they use AI for a particular task - especially those which are easiest for AI to do
- **Reflect on the relationship** (e.g. *Task Criticality, Agency, and Friction*)
- **Include an AI opt-out option**: but not an opt-out of being critical

Use of AI	Details	Appendix
Idea generation/development: Yes [ ] No [ ]		
Research: Yes [ ] No [ ]		
Planning/strategy: Yes [ ] No [ ]		
Data analysis/cleaning: Yes [ ] No [ ]		
Interview sourcing/planning: Yes [ ] No [ ]		
Drafting emails etc: Yes [ ] No [ ]		
Drafting: Yes [ ] No [ ]		
Image creation: Yes [ ] No [ ]		
Editing/feedback: Yes [ ] No [ ]		

Use the code of conduct as a framework

1. “Respect and protect **personal data**. Use data minimisation and anonymisation where possible. Do not disclose personal, confidential or third-party proprietary data to public AI services without the written approval of the Chief Information Officer and Data Protection Officer.
2. “Ensure that AI systems do not perpetuate or amplify **bias and discrimination**. Regularly audit models for fairness
3. **Design** AI systems to be **inclusive and usable** by people of all abilities.
4. “Maintain **human oversight**”

“Evaluate how you did each of these”

Lit reviews and methodologies in the AI era

What learning objectives are lit reviews for? Is this an opportunity to move students from summarisation to more critical higher order activity?

- **AI used for a first-go**: critique the results, and how they can be/were improved. Can also be assessed on critical prompt design.
- **AI is used for a second-go**: get feedback from AI and respond to it (new problem: how do you ensure the response isn't AI)
- **AI is used in parallel**: your and AI versions are compared and critiqued
- **Assess process not product**: document how they found and collected the literature and identified it as relevant

For a literature review

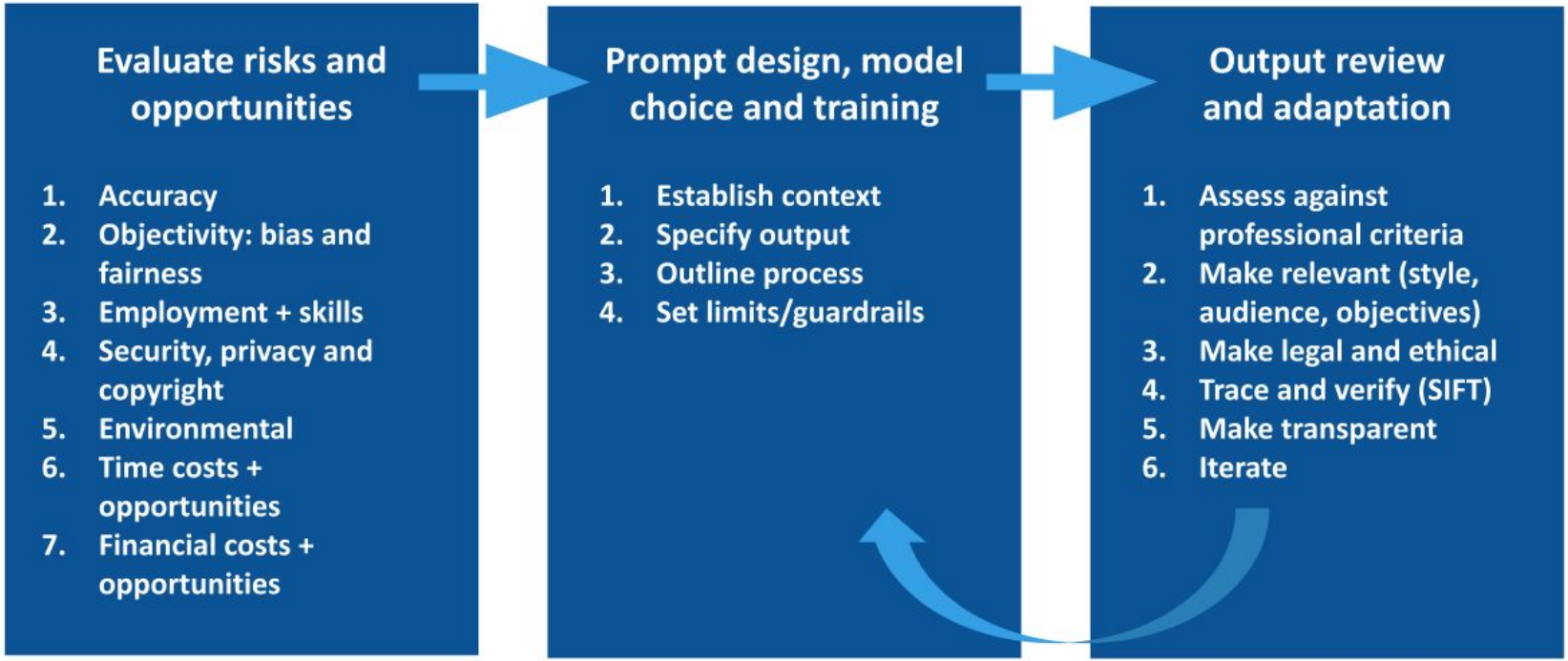
Design a prompt which asks for a draft lit review and attempts to address risks of **accuracy and bias.** Tips:

- **Define explicitly what ‘good’ quality involves**
- **Identify what information will be needed to judge it**
- **Describe the steps that should be followed (or attach)**
- **Include examples**
- **Identify what you *don’t* want it to do**

Prompt design techniques

- **N-shot prompting**: including examples
- **Chain of Thought (CoT)**: describing steps
- **Negative prompting**: listing what not to do
- **RAG**: adding information (data, docs, articles, key facts)
- **Role prompting**: giving a role (context)
- **Journey prompting**: asking for process not product (to avoid deskilling)

Three steps of professional genAI use



Training might also include harnesses, models, collecting training data, optimisation

Paul Bradshaw 2026

Also applies to other aspects of research?

- **AI used for a first-go**: results treated as hypothesis generation to be critiqued and verified
- **AI is used for a second-go**: identify potential blind spots/issues not considered, and iterate
- **AI is used in parallel**: your and AI versions are compared and critiqued (e.g. do you arrive at the same result?)
- **Assess process not product**: focus on exploration and experimentation over results

“As some stages of scientific research become easier, bottlenecks shift downstream. **Scientists report an increased backlog of untested hypotheses and substantial demand for output verification**”

It’s not the same world

AI in Science: Early Insights (FT summary)

Actor-specific problems: FIRE!

“AI cannot deal with what we call “actor-specificity.” Actor-specific decisions and problems are:

- **Forward-looking** (not based on historical data)
- **Individual and idiosyncratic** (personal, not predictable)
- **Reasoning-intensive** (e.g. reframing, counter factuals)
- **Experimental** (requires intervention)

Felin, T., Sako, M. & Hullman, J. AI and actor-specific decisions. AI & Soc (2026).
https://doi.org/10.1007/s00146-026-03202-7

Prompts as critical thinking/knowledge

Three components of effective prompt design which also function as effective elements of assessment (Cain 2023)

- **Comprehensive content knowledge**: e.g. teaching the AI a concept
- **Critical thinking**: e.g. prompting or iterating critically
- **Iterative design approach**: e.g. choosing from options

‘Writing as thinking’ applies to prompt design too.

AI diary example: researching an issue

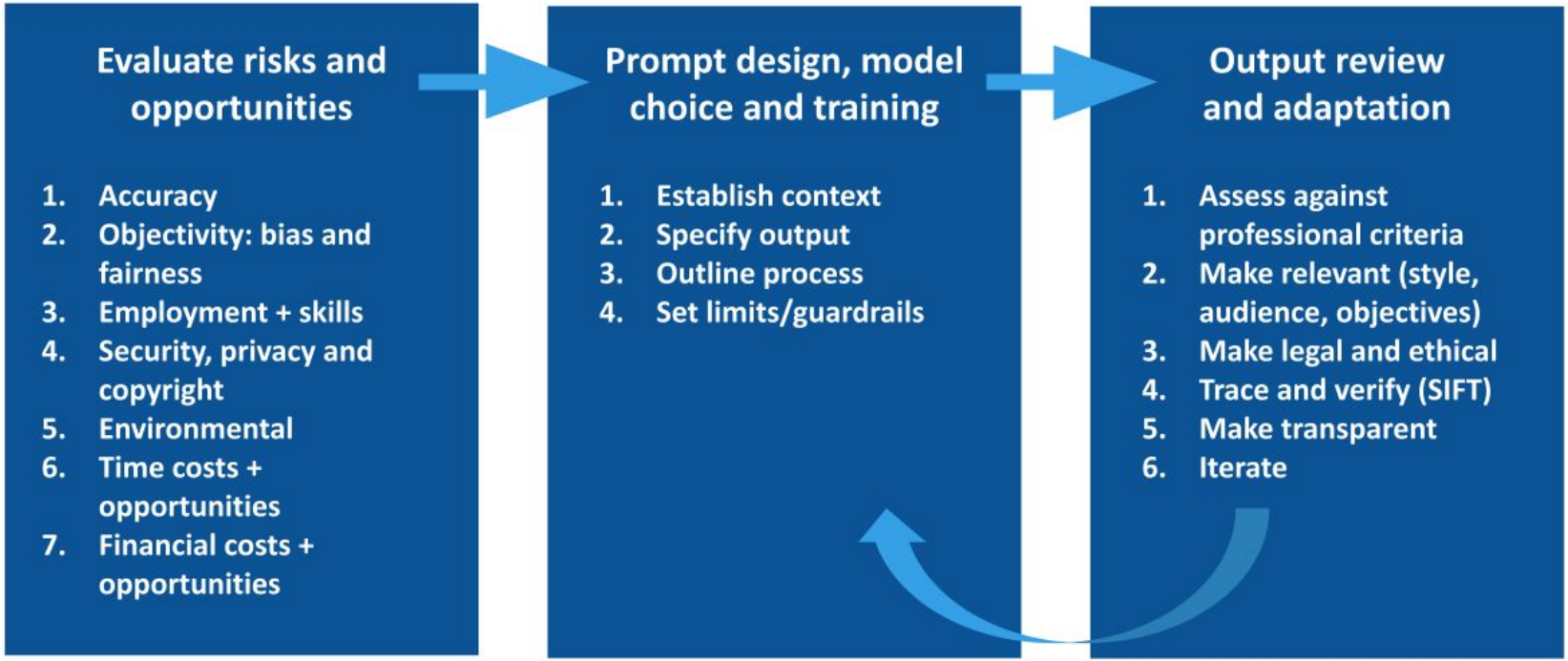
This is an example of using the AI diary to document the process of researching an issue. The knowledge applied in this entry is linked in the notes, and the prompts demonstrate how well that source is understood.

Interactions (include dates) ***Please label 'PROMPT' and 'RESPONSE' clearly**, using letters and numbers to indicate prompts and responses that are part of the same conversation (e.g. PROMPT A1 for the first prompt in an interaction, and PROMPT A2 for the second prompt in the same interaction)*	**Notes** **Please include links** to any sources of concepts/ practices etc. that you mention.
PROMPT AX1 (23/7/26): ChatGPT Analyse: '30 years on from race riots, Oldham is more segregated than ever'	Using Mike Caulfield's 4 tips for better prompting with research tasks - he suggests using 'analyse' as one way to begin the conversation https://mikecaulfield.substack.com/p/four-tips-for-better-prompting
RESPONSE AX1 The statement **"30 years on from race riots, Oldham is more segregated than ever"** is a strong claim that combines a factual observation with an implicit judgement. A good analysis considers the historical context, the evidence for segregation, and the reasons why integration has proved difficult.	Following Mike's instructions, I ignore this response as 'warming up' and move straight onto step 2: focusing on the follow up.

E.g. AI diaries/transcripts

- **Prompt design techniques** demonstrate application of professional practice (link to reading)
- **Training the AI**: by summarising their own learning (attributed)
- **Choosing from AI options** showing critical awareness and knowledge of professional standards (+ reflection)
- **Adapting/incorporating** AI output critically
- **Risk assessment** of bias, accuracy, deskilling, environment, etc.

Three steps of professional genAI use



Training might also include harnesses, models, collecting training data, optimisation

Paul Bradshaw 2026

For an AI chatbot response...

Evaluate the response critically

- **What are you assessing it against?** (Standards, etc)
- What needs to be done to make it **relevant**?
- **Legal? Ethical?**
- What do you need to **trace and verify**?
- How might you **iterate** next?

In-person assessment

- **Employers moving to in-person assessment** to prevent AI use
- **Addresses anxiety and low confidence**
- **Focus on process not product**: a conversation *not a presentation*
- **Scenario-based, with live inputs**: applying the knowledge, not reciting it

Key points

1. **Remove ambiguity, build transparency and trust**
2. **Most students don't know *how* to negotiate AI**, either critically or 'legally' (within the university guidelines). Support them to enter an AI-embedded world with confidence, not ignorance.
3. **Use AI critically** — you can't identify it, educate or guide students if you don't have an applied understanding of its tells and "jagged intelligence"

Where to go next:

- **Newsletters**: Mike Caulfield's The End(s) of Argument
  - Ethan Mollick's One Useful Thing
  - Eytan Adar: AI-Native PhD Students (post)
- **Books**: Cory Doctorow The Reverse Centaur's Guide to Life After AI
  - Dan Davies The Unaccountability Machine
- **Papers**: Bearman & Ajjawi: Pedagogy for a world with artificial intelligence. BJET, May 2023
  - Felin, Sako and Hullman: AI and actor-specific decisions, AI & Society, July 2026
  - Shaw & Nave: How AI is Reshaping Human Reasoning, Feb 2026
  - Romeo & Conti: Exploring automation bias in human–AI collaboration: a review, 2025
  - Microsoft: The Impact of genAI on Critical Thinking / MIT: Your Brain on ChatGPT
- **Podcast**: Carl Miller: Power Trip: the age of AI

Recommendations (checklist)

1. **Have the same evidence threshold** for all modules
2. **Standardise and teach AI declaration and documentation**
3. **Schedule a viva week** so students expect it (and can't avoid it)
4. **Include AI transparency policy in briefs** (if students upload it to AI, generated material should declare use and include specific context)
5. **Develop in-person assessments** such as job interviews, appraisals, pitching, team meetings, etc. to focus on process and application of knowledge
6. **If a format is curatorial, preempt AI usage**: use it as an opportunity to get students to compare their output with AI's, or edit AI versions. They will have to justify to others why it would be written by a human in 2026, 2036 etc.